

# The Bronze Gate

An Urban Intrigue Adventure for Fate's Edge

Set down by the fires of Castra Ferrum

Year of the Iron Harvest



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# 1 How to Run This Adventure

## Previously in Fate's Edge

Your players have survived the bandit attack on Millhaven (*Blood and Silk*) and brokered peace at the Valvano Ford (*Beyond Millhaven*). They have earned the trust of the Vilikari merchant Tema and may have met Khatun Sarnai (Ykrul chieftain) and Captain Rusk (Black Banner mercenary). They carry a Letter of Introduction to a Vilikari lord and have begun to build a reputation. Now they are drawn into the politics of Castra Ferrum, where old grudges and cursed relics threaten to ignite a new war.

The Bronze Gate is a Tier I–II adventure, suitable for characters who have earned 30–60 XP. It assumes familiarity with the core resolution loop, Position, DV, Boons, and clocks. The adventure introduces terrestrial patronage, Roman-style wards,

## The Prefect's Wisdom

Set the DV low. Let the debt do the work. Every seal, every handshake, every whispered promise is a chain – and chains, once forged, are not easily broken.

## 1.1 Adventure Background

Castra Ferrum stands at the northern edge of the province, a walled city built atop a Ykrul burial ground. The Bronze Gate is the only pass through the mountains for three weeks' march. Ecktorian officers, tax farmers, and priest-magistrates hold sway through a web of patronage; a favor given is a debt recorded, a debt recorded is a chain forged.

The Ykrul clans camp beyond the walls, allowed inside only on market days. They sacked the city four times in living memory. Every Ecktorian has a grandfa-

ther who fell under a Ykrul arrow. The Vilikari traders who bring grain and iron are looked down upon by the elite – "cart-lords" and "ledger-lickers" – and the Black Banner mercenaries camp in the Field of Broken Standards, selling steel to whoever can pay.

Prefect Gaius Marcellus, commander of the garrison, has recovered a lost relic: the Iron Seal of Varus, the standard of the Ninth Hispania Legion, destroyed by the Ykrul two centuries ago. The seal binds oaths with a wasting curse; any who swears on it and lies sickens and dies. Marcellus intends to use it to force Khatun Sarnai, the Ykrul chieftain, to swear a non-raiding treaty. Sarnai refuses to enter the city, and the seal still carries the old curse – it harms Ecktorians as well.

The party is hired by Tema, a Vilikari grain merchant, to steal the seal. She means to give it to Sarnai as a gesture of peace, opening the steppe trade route. But Marcellus's rival, Censor Cassia, wants the seal destroyed, and a Black Banner captain named Rusk wants to sell it to the highest bidder – he has already hired a thief called Quick Lena to take it first.

## 1.2 What the Party Should Know

At the start of the adventure, the players know the following:

- The Bronze Gate is the only pass through the mountains. Control of the gate is control of trade.
- Prefect Marcellus has a relic that can force oaths. He means to use it on the Ykrul.
- Khatun Sarnai will not meet inside the walls. She demands the seal as *wergild* for the desecrated burial ground beneath the gate.
- Tema offers a fortune in silver if the party retrieves the seal for her.
- A thief named Quick Lena works for Captain Rusk. She is already casing the tribunal.

## 1.3 New Mechanics for Players

### 1.3.1 Terrestrial Patrons and Debt Clocks

Prefect Marcellus, Censor Cassia, and Khatun Sarnai each offer a **Debt Clock** [4]. Accepting a favor – legal protection, a map, a distraction – marks one segment. When the clock fills, the patron calls in the debt. Refusal turns the patron into an enemy.

### Marcellus's Ledger

*"I do not ask for loyalty. I ask for results. Fail me, and the Bronze Gate will close to you forever."*

— Prefect Marcellus

#### 1.3.2 Traps and Wards (Roman Flavor)

Traps use the tag system. The most common in Castra Ferrum are:

- (*Vigilum Signum*) – a bell triggered by thread or pressure. Raises the Watch Patrol clock. Countered by Stealth or cutting the thread.
- (*Plumbum Manus*) – a lead-weighted net drops from the ceiling. Restrains until freed with Body+Athletics DV3. Countered by a blade or .
- (*Limen Sacrum*) – a blessed threshold that burns any non-legionary who crosses. Causes 1 Fatigue per crossing. Countered by offering a coin to the *Lares* (household gods) or reciting a legion password (Wits+Lore DV3).
- (*Tabula Defixionis*) – a lead tablet hidden in a wall or under a floor. Inflicts a condition such as *Marked by Mars* (enemies gain +1 die to track you). Countered by finding and smashing the tablet (Wits+Investigation DV4).

#### 1.3.3 Quick Lena's Talents

Quick Lena uses talents from the *Velvet Touch*. Her most dangerous is **The Ghost Did It** – once per arc, a crime she commits leaves no traceable evidence. She also has **Always Another Exit** (she can declare an escape route when cornered) and **Light Fingers** (she can lift a small object mid-conversation without a roll).

## 1.4 Factions and Key NPCs

| Faction            | Leader                 | Goal                                    | Leverage / S                    |
|--------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Ecktorian Tribunal | Prefect Marcel-<br>lus | Enforce order, control the<br>seal      | Military esco<br>keys, legal im |
| Censor's Office    | Censor Cassia          | Destroy the seal, expose Mar-<br>cellus | Archive acces<br>nity from pros |
| Ykrul Grey Ash     | Khatun Sarnai          | Protect her people, reopen<br>trade     | Safe passage,<br>mounts, Ykrul  |

|                  |              |                             |                                        |                    |
|------------------|--------------|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Vilikari Traders | Tema         | Open steppe route for grain | Trade house, festivals                 | creditors, forgers |
| Black Banner     | Captain Rusk | Get paid, get out           | Mercenary squad (battle scene), battle |                    |

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1.4.1 Prefect Gaius Marcellus

A wiry, scarred veteran with a voice like a parade ground. He speaks in clipped phrases and never repeats himself. He genuinely believes the seal will bring peace – and also consolidate his power. His debt clock is his primary mechanic.

1.4.2 Censor Cassia

A thin, aging woman with ink-stained fingers. Her left eye is a polished silver disc – a magical lens that reveals lies. She is Marcellus’s political rival and knows the seal’s curse is still active.

1.4.3 Khatun Sarnai

Proud, grieving, hard. Her nephew was killed by a Vilikari caravan. She will not trust Eкторians, but she respects those who keep their word. She remembers the party from earlier adventures (if any).

1.4.4 "Quick" Lena

A Sidhi rogue with mismatched eyes and a nervous laugh. She works for Rusk, not out of loyalty but desperation – she owes a debt to a Sidhi smuggler named Kaelen. She is not evil, but she is fast, and she does not like losing.

1.4.5 Captain Rusk

A former Ykrul hostage, now leading a Black Banner company. He owes no loyalty to any nation. He will sell the seal to whoever pays best – but he is haunted by a promise he made to a dying legionary.



## 2 Session One – The Bronze Gate

### 2.1 Opening Scene – Tema’s Warehouse

The party meets Tema in the Vilikari quarter, a district of tanneries and cheap taverns. The air smells of lime and wet wool. Tema is thinner than they remember, her hands stained with grain dust.

#### What Tema Offers

- 200 silver marks (the party’s weight in coin)
- A **String: Tema’s Trust** – once per arc, she will smuggle a small object past any checkpoint
- A Letter of Introduction to a Vilikari lord in the south (a future hook)

She needs the **Iron Seal of Varus** stolen from the Prefect’s tribunal. She wants to give it to Sarnai as a peace offering.

### 2.2 The Bronze Gate – A Tour of Factions

Run this as a social tour. The party can visit each location in any order. No rolls are required unless the players initiate conflict.

#### 2.2.1 The Gate Itself

The portcullis is bronze-banded iron, etched with the names of every legionary who died defending it. A Censor’s clerk keeps the *Ledger of Blood* – a book

recording every soul who passes. The Ykrul call it the Weeping Gate; they say the ghosts scratch the stones at night.

**Mechanical effect:** The gate is a (*Limen Sacrum*). Non-Ecktorians must pay 1 silver or present a **Bronze Pass** (a String) to cross. Ykrul are not allowed inside except on market days.

### 2.2.2 Prefect Marcellus – The Tribunal

The tribunal is a fortified hall inside the Praetorium. Marcellus invites the party (if they have a patron or bribe a guard) and offers a job: retrieve a stolen tax tablet from a Vilikari smuggler. Reward: a **Bronze Pass** (one free crossing). Accepting starts his **Debt Clock** [4].

### 2.2.3 Censor Cassia – The Archive

Cassia's office is a labyrinth of scrolls and curse tablets awaiting destruction. She offers a different task: steal a copy of Marcellus's correspondence to prove he is misusing the seal. Reward: an **Archive Key** (+1 die to Lore rolls in the city) and her protection. She demands a **String: A Favor to the Censor**.

### 2.2.4 Khatun Sarnai – The Ykrul Camp

Outside the walls, a ring of felt wagons guarded by wolf-banners. Sarnai will not enter the city. She demands the seal as wergild for the desecrated burial ground. If the party swears an oath to bring it to her, she offers a **Ykrul Guide** (a Cap 2 follower who knows the steppe).

### 2.2.5 Captain Rusk – The Field of Broken Standards

Rusk's camp is a ragged collection of tents and corrals. He is friendly but shrewd. He has already hired Quick Lena to steal the seal. He offers the party a cut if they help – or a bribe to stay out of his way. He has his own **Debt Clock** [4] (he owes a smuggler named Kaelen). Paying his debt wins a temporary alliance.

## 2.3 End of Session One – The Heist Clock

Start a **Heist Clock** [6]. Each downtime scene (or at the end of each session), tick it +1. When it fills, Quick Lena steals the seal first – the rest of the adventure becomes a chase.

The party should choose at least one patron by the end of the session.

## 3 Session Two – The Tribunal Heist

### 3.1 Opening Scene – The Night Before

The party stakes out the tribunal. They can bribe a guard (Presence+Streetwise DV3, cost 1 Boon or 10 silver), steal a patrol schedule (Wits+Stealth DV4), get a map from Cassia (requires her favor), or wait for a storm (the guards are distracted, but the storm wakes the curse).

Start a **Watch Patrol Clock [4]**. Each failed Stealth roll ticks it. When full, the alarm is raised.

#### Clock Triggers

##### Watch Patrol Clock advances +1 when:

- A Stealth roll fails.
- A trap's triggers.
- A guard is not silenced before they can shout.

##### Heist Clock advances +1 when:

- A downtime scene ends.
- The party spends a full hour debating without action (GM's call).
- A partial success on a critical roll creates a delay (e.g., the lockpick breaks).

## 3.2 Chamber One – The Armory

**Ward:** + . Lead sheets on the floor trigger a bell and a net.

**Counter:** Wits+Tinker DV4 to disable. On a partial, the bell rings but the net fails – tick Watch Patrol +1.

**Optional:** A curse tablet hidden in the wall (Wits+Investigation DV5). If found, it reveals Marcellus has been using the seal to curse rivals. This is a

**String:** Marcellus’s Treason.

## 3.3 Chamber Two – The Scriptorium

**Ward:** (*Limen Sacrum*). The door burns non-legionaries.

**Counter:** Recite a legion password (Wits+Lore DV3) or offer a coin to the *Lares* (1 Boon or 1 silver). Failure costs 1 Fatigue; the guard beyond hears the cry.

Inside: a map of the city marked with Ykrul trade routes, and a forged census tablet showing Marcellus skimming grain tithes – another String.

## 3.4 Chamber Three – The Reliquary

The seal rests in a lead-lined chest on an altar to Mars. Quick Lena is already there, trying to crack the lock.

**Ward:** . Anyone who opens the chest without a blessing gains *Marked by Mars* – enemies gain +1 die to track them.

**Counter:** Pray to Mars (Spirit+Lore DV3) or smash the curse tablet hidden under the altar (Wits+Investigation DV4, costs one round).

### 3.4.1 Confronting Quick Lena

Lena is not a fighter. She will negotiate: split the reward, or she will walk away. A Presence+Sway DV3 convinces her. On failure, she uses *Always Another Exit* – a smoke bomb and escape – but drops her lockpicks (a Minor Asset: +1 die to open locks). Tick Watch Patrol +1.

If the party fights, Lena has Harm 2, Stealth 3, Subterfuge 2. She uses *Light Fingers* to steal a weapon mid-combat (Wits+Subterfuge vs PC’s Wits+Notice). At Harm 2 she surrenders.

## 3.5 Escape – Skill Challenge

The party must exit before the Watch Patrol clock fills. Run this as a **skill challenge**: the players need **3 successes before 2 failures**. Each PC describes how they contribute (Stealth to avoid patrols, Command to give orders, Deception to bluff past a guard, Athletics to climb a wall). The GM sets DVbased on the approach (typically 3).

Complications on failure:

- A guard spots the party – tick Watch Patrol +1. The PC may spend 1 Boon to create a distraction and avoid the tick.
- A door is locked that wasn't before – the party must find another route (adds 1 segment to the challenge).
- Rusk's mercenaries arrive (if the Heist Clock is at 4+ segments). The party must fight or bribe them.

If the clock fills, run a brief chase. On failure, they are arrested – Cassia may bail them out in exchange for the seal, or Marcellus may offer a deal.



# 4 Session Three – The Curse Unsealed

## 4.1 Opening Scene – The Seal’s Whisper

The seal still carries the old curse. Anyone who sleeps near it must make Spirit+Resolve DV4 or gain *Varus’s Whispers* (–1 die to resist persuasion). The curse worsens each night.

Rusk and Lena (if she escaped) are hunting them. Marcellus has declared them outlaws.

## 4.2 The Final Confrontation

The location depends on the party’s chosen patron:

- **The Bronze Gate** (siding with Sarnai). Rusk’s mercenaries attack at midnight.
- **The Archive** (siding with Cassia). She performs a ritual to destroy the seal. Marcellus arrives with guards.
- **The Praetorium** (siding with Marcellus). He forces the party to bind Sarnai’s oath. The curse backfires.

## 4.3 Breaking the Curse – Three Ways

### 4.3.1 Return the Seal to the Ykrul

Give it to Sarnai. She buries it under a cairn with a steppe ritual. The curse ends. Sarnai opens the trade route. Marcellus becomes a permanent enemy. **Cost:** The party loses any favor with Marcellus; his Debt Clock becomes a Hunt Clock [6].

### 4.3.2 Destroy the Seal with Fire

A ritual (Spirit+Arcana DV6). On success, the seal shatters. On a partial, it shatters but the curse transfers to the one who strikes it – that PC gains *Varus's Scourge* (1 Fatigue each dawn until they atone). Cassia rewards a **Censor's Seal** (one free legal pardon). **Cost:** Marcellus becomes a permanent enemy; Rusk may demand compensation.

### 4.3.3 Bind the Seal with a New Oath

Swear a treaty between Marcellus, Sarnai, and Tema. Requires a **Persuasion Clock [6]** for each faction. On success, the curse transforms into a blessing – the gate harms no one. The party gains a String with all three factions. Marcellus still owes them a debt (his Debt Clock remains, but now it's a favor they can call). **Cost:** The party must mediate a tense ceremony; any failed roll during the oath-swearing triggers a complication (e.g., a Ykrul warrior challenges the prefect to a duel).

## 4.4 Ending – The Gate Opens

At dawn, the portcullis rises. Describe the scene: the Ykrul riders waiting, the merchants with their carts, the legionaries saluting. Then ask each player: *"What does your character want now? And what are you willing to owe to get it?"*

### Continuing the Campaign

The party now has enemies (Marcellus, perhaps Rusk) and allies (Sarnai, Cassia, Tema). Their reputation precedes them. Future adventures could involve:

- Marcellus seeking revenge through legal or military means.
- A Ykrul uprising sparked by the broken curse.
- Rusk's debt to Kaelen coming due – and the party being dragged into Sidhi smuggling politics.
- The Censor calling in her favor to expose a larger conspiracy.



# 5 Advancement and Rewards

## 5.1 Experience Points (8–12 xPper PC)

- Attendance: +2
- Retrieve the seal: +2
- Break or secure the curse (any method): +2
- Neutralize Quick Lena (negotiation or combat): +1
- Gain a String from two different factions: +1 per faction (max +2)
- Complete a Terrestrial Patron's Debt Clock: +1
- Personal goal (from player's own backstory): +1–2

## 5.2 Strings and Assets

- **Bronze Pass** – One free crossing of the Bronze Gate.
- **Archive Key** – +1 die to Lore rolls in Castra Ferrum.
- **Sarnai's Favor** – Ykrul safe passage for one journey.
- **Marcellus's Debt [4]** – Track this clock. When full, he demands a dangerous service.
- **Censor's Seal** – One free legal pardon (destroyed after use).
- **Varus's Shard** – A piece of the broken seal. Once per arc, curse a target with –1 die to all rolls for one scene; user also takes 1 Fatigue.



# 6 Appendix – Quick Reference

## 6.1 Clock Summary

| Clock          | Segments | Ticks                            | When F                 |
|----------------|----------|----------------------------------|------------------------|
| Heist (Lena)   | 6        | End of each downtime scene       | Lena steal first – cha |
| Watch Patrol   | 4        | Failed Stealth, triggered alarms | Guards a rounds        |
| Marcellus Debt | 4        | Accept his favors                | He deman gerous tas    |
| Rusk Debt      | 4        | Party asks him for help          | He dema seal or pa     |

## 6.2 Trap Tags (Roman Flavor)

| Tag | Roman Name               | Effect                          | Counter                  |
|-----|--------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------|
|     | <i>Vigilum Signum</i>    | Bell rings, ticks Watch Pa-trol | Stealth, cut threa       |
|     | <i>Plumbum Manus</i>     | Net restrains                   | Athletics DV3 break      |
|     | <i>Limen Sacrum</i>      | Burns non-legionary             | Offer coin, rec password |
|     | <i>Tabula Defixionis</i> | Inflicts condition              | Smash the tablet         |

## 6.3 NPC Quick Stats

### 6.3.1 Quick Lena – Rogue (Tier II)

Wits 3, Stealth 3, Subterfuge 2. Talents: *Light Fingers*, *Always Another Exit*, *The Ghost Did It* (once). Harm 2.

### 6.3.2 Prefect Marcellus – Terrestrial Patron (Tier III)

No combat. Offers Debt Clock. Leverage: guards, jail, military escort.

### 6.3.3 Censor Cassia – Sage (Tier II)

Wits 4, Lore 3, Arcana 2. Can see lies through her silver eye (automatically detect Deception DV4 or less).

### 6.3.4 Khatun Sarnai – Warrior (Tier II)

Body 3, Melee 3, Command 2. Tracks honor debts separately.

### 6.3.5 Captain Rusk – Mercenary Captain (Tier II)

Body 3, Melee 3, Command 2. His personal Debt Clock [4] is owed to the smuggler Kaelen.

## 7 Colophon

This account was set down in the Prefect's own scriptorium, by lamplight, on paper seized from a Vilikari caravan. The ink is lamp-black and the ash of a burned treaty. The binding is legionary leather, stained with rust.

The gate still stands. The debts remain unpaid.

— Set down by a clerk of the Bronze Gate, Year of the Iron Harvest